WAR OF THE LEAGUE OF AUGSBURG

ACTION OF JUNE 29, 1694



Date June 29, 1694
Forces French: 6 warships: Dutch: 8 warships
Losses French: none; Dutch: 3 warships captured

Location Off Texel, North Sea

With the French people facing starvation after bad harvests, Jean Bart was dispatched to escort a large grain convoy crossing the North Sea. He met the convoy off Texel—in the possession of a Dutch flotilla that had captured it. Bart held the weather gage and, although outnumbered, attacked the Dutch ships fiercely. His flagship *Maure* was almost disabled by the guns of the Dutch flagship *Prins Friso*, but he nonetheless boarded and captured her. Two other Dutch ships were also taken and the rest fled. Bart brought the 120 ships of the convoy with their invaluable cargo safely to port in France.

1651–1702

JEAN BART

FRENCH PRIVATEER AND ADMIRAL

The son of a Dunkirk fisherman, Jean Bart proved from an early age an outstanding sailor and fighter. He was the leader of the Dunkirk privateers by 1676 and rose to the rank of admiral in the French navy despite his lack of noble birth. In 1689 he was captured by the English but escaped after three days and crossed from Plymouth to Brittany in a rowing boat. He was ennobled after saving France from starvation by the rescue of a grain convoy captured by the Dutch in June 1694. A supreme commerce raider, Bart repeatedly defied English efforts to blockade him in port and is credited with capturing over 300 ships in his career. His exploits made him a French national hero.



WAR OF THE LEAGUE OF AUGSBURG

DOGGER BANK



Date June 17, 1696
Forces French: 7 warships: Dutch: 5 warships
Losses French: none; Dutch: 5 warships, 25 merchant ships

Location Dogger Bank, North Sea

Blockaded inside Dunkirk by an English squadron under Admiral John Benbow, Jean Bart slipped out of harbor on a misty night in June 1696 and headed for the North Sea, fruitful ground for commerce raiding. On June 17 the French happened upon a Dutch convoy of a large number of merchant vessels escorted by five frigates. Since Bart had under his command seven naval warships mounting from 36 to 54 guns, supported by two privateers, it was an unequal contest. Bart's flagship *Maure* and the other naval ships engaged the Dutch escorts, while the privateers set about pursuing and overtaking the merchant ships. The fight began at 7:00 p.m. and was hotly contested. The Dutch flagship *Raadhuis van Haarlem* duelled valiantly with *Maure*, which lost 15 of her crew, killed before forcing her opponent to surrender. The rest of the escorts also struck their colors and the entire convoy was captured.

However, Benbow's blockade squadron and a group of Dutch warships were searching for Bart and their arrival on the scene forced the French to depart in haste. They set fire to most of the ships they had captured and fled, carrying some 1,200 prisoners with them. Dodging the English and Dutch ships pursuing them, they sailed along the Norwegian coast to Denmark. Bart eventually slipped back into Dunkirk in late September. The loss of the convoy was a serious blow to Dutch merchants and a demonstration of the limitations of Anglo-Dutch command of the sea.

WAR OF THE SPANISH SUCCESSION

VIGO BAY



Date October 23, 1702
Forces English and Dutch: 28 ships of the line; French and Spanish: 17 ships of the line
Losses English and Dutch: none; French and Spanish: all ships destroyed or captured

Location Vigo Bay, northern Spain

An Anglo-Dutch fleet commanded by Admiral Sir George Rooke was sent to attack the Spanish port of Cadiz. At the same time French Vice Admiral Louis Rousselet de Chateau-Renault was escorting a Spanish treasure fleet across the Atlantic from Cuba. Hearing of the presence of enemy ships at Cadiz, the treasure fleet prudently diverted to Vigo, where the unloading of its silver bullion got under way.

Rooke's raid on Cadiz was a failure, but on his way home he learned of the arrival of the treasure ships in Vigo and seized the opportunity to redeem himself. The harbor was well defended, its entrance blocked by a boom of masts chained together, covered by the fire of shore batteries and the guns of ships anchored inside. Rooke landed troops to attack the Spanish forts and ordered the British and Dutch vice admirals Thomas Hopsonn and Philip van der Goes to sail in and break through the boom. The Allied ships came in for very heavy punishment. Hopsonn's *Torbay* was especially hard hit and he was obliged to shift his flag to *Monmouth*. But the boom was breached and the Allies broke into the harbor. Believing he had no chance in a fight, Chateau-Renault ordered his captains to fire their ships. The harbor was soon an amazing spectacle of blazing and exploding vessels. The Allies succeeded in capturing some of the ships before fire took hold, including galleons that still had bullion and other valuables worth £14,000 on board. Apart from ships and treasure, the disaster cost the French and Spanish some 2,000 casualties. English and Dutch dead and wounded numbered around 800.



Commemorative medal
Hercules seizes a French soldier holding the Golden Fleece—a reference to Spanish treasure.



Start of the attack on Vigo Harbor
Torbay leads the Anglo-Dutch ships round the headland to bombard the boom placed across the harbor. In the foreground, the attacking force has landed troops on the shore south of the harbor.